the Labour ranks and the welfare state advocates among the conservatives. This could lead to a genuine centrist party.

Unfortunately, despite a heady start in 1981, SDP electoral dividends plunged two years later. After a poor show in the 1983 general election in which party president Shirley Williams lost her seat, a debate started on its political future. The leaders, though, remained close to India. Finally the SDP was merged with the Liberal Party in 1988 and became part of a coalition government in 2010.

The Nuclear Arms Battle

Besides predicting political futures, R&AW has also been involved in passing on information to India's military strategists. This is particularly important because the poor relationship with Pakistan means that India is vulnerable to having developed countries play good cop-bad cop. It was common in the 1970s and 1980s for American and Soviet agencies to provide tip-offs against one another as part of their respective disinformation campaigns. After India's nuclear test in 1974, the Americans sold F-16 fighter jets to Pakistan but sent feelers to Delhi about signing up for nuclear disarmament. India was in favour of total nuclear disarmament but asked for other countries in possession of weapons of mass destruction to do the same. The Americans, Soviets and other developed countries were unwilling. Thus, the R&AW, coordinating with the MEA, helped the Indian government formulate its strategy and ensure that the country was not pressured to sign the discriminatory piece of international legislation.

When Pakistan joined the nuclear arms race as a deterrent to India's capability, the R&AW had pointed out that though nuclear weapon states made public statements about non-